Advanced Keyboard Technique

More keys, broad arpeggios, comfortable octaves and bass-to-chord travel.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Fluent major scales in more keys
2. Harmonic and melodic minor
3. Broad arpeggios with continuous movement
4. Comfortable octaves and lighter alternatives
5. Bass-to-chord accompaniment
6. Come Thou Fount: travelling accompaniment
7. Crown Him with Many Crowns: octave colour
8. Eternal Father, Strong to Save: flowing piano

1. Fluent major scales in more keys

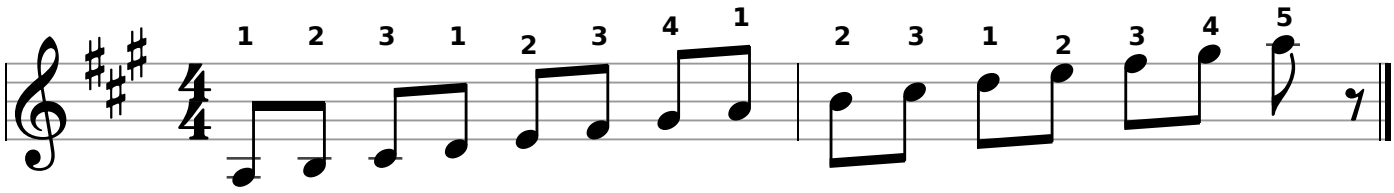
Plan black-key fingerings and even crossings in A and E.

Fluent major scales in more keys

Treat black keys as landmarks. In right-hand A and E major the usual ascending pattern begins 1-2-3, crosses to 1, then continues 2-3-4 before the next crossing. Practise one hand at a time, then match both hands offline. Keep the thumb close to the keys and move the arm along the scale. Add B-flat, E-flat and A-flat from their own fingering patterns; do not reuse C fingering blindly.

Practise · A major across two octaves

Use finger 1 at the middle A. Keep G-sharp light before the crossing.



Opening example · 4/4 · A · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · E major and return

Practise the crossing in both directions; keep the same pulse.

Practise independently

Descend the A scale offline, then practise the left hand separately with a planned fingering. Expand to four octaves only when two sound even and the crossings stay free.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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2. Harmonic and melodic minor
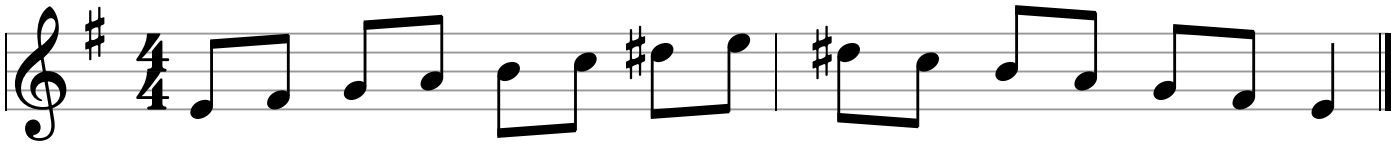
Choose a minor form by its melodic and harmonic purpose.

Harmonic and melodic minor

Harmonic minor raises scale degree 7 to strengthen the dominant. In the common classical melodic-minor exercise, degrees 6 and 7 rise on the ascent and return to natural minor on the descent. Actual music may use either form in either direction. In E minor, compare C-D, C-D-sharp and C-sharp-D-sharp before returning to E. Listen to the sound of each choice, not just its fingering.

Practise · E harmonic minor

Hear D-sharp lean toward E, then descend with the same raised seventh.



Opening example · 4/4 · Em · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · E melodic-minor exercise

Raise C and D on the ascent; return to C and D natural on the descent.

> **Review**
>
> Which notes rise in the common ascending melodic-minor exercise?
>
> **Answer:** Degrees 6 and 7 Degrees 6 and 7 rise; the exercise commonly descends in natural minor. Musical passages can vary.

Practise independently

Sing the upper four notes of each form. Then transpose the comparison to A minor offline. Explain how a raised seventh changes the pull toward the tonic.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

3. Broad arpeggios with continuous movement

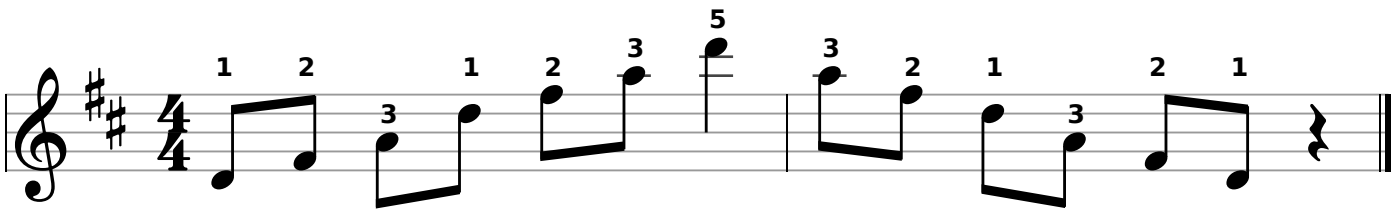
Coordinate crossings without holding an open stretch.

Broad arpeggios with continuous movement

Locate the chord tones before choosing a fingering. Let the forearm move toward the next octave while the current fingers finish. Practise the crossing pair without twisting the wrist. The left-hand C fingering below uses 5-4-2-1 across one octave, then 4 after the thumb when continuing. A small hand may need another comfortable plan. Keep the sound even at the joins.

Practise · Right-hand D-major arpeggio

Move through 1-2-3, then prepare 1 on the next D.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left-hand C-major arpeggio

Release each note as needed so the arm can travel; do not freeze the thumb.

Practise independently

Compare the volume before and after every crossing. Loop a crossing with its approach note. Extend the same movement to a hymn accompaniment only after the technical pattern feels settled.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

4. Comfortable octaves and lighter alternatives

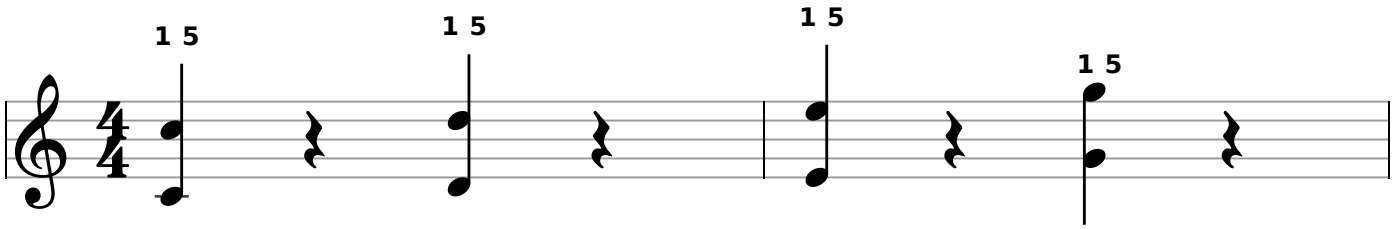
Use release and arm movement instead of gripping.

Comfortable octaves and lighter alternatives

Only practise blocked octaves if your hand spans them comfortably. Keep the hand elastic and release between attacks; do not lock the wrist or force the fingers apart. Begin slowly and softly with a few repetitions. A single melody note or a broken octave is a valid substitute. Octave sound should serve a climactic phrase, not make every line heavy.

Practise · Short octave groups

Use 1-5 only if comfortable. Otherwise select one hand and play the upper note as an offline alternative.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Broken-octave alternative

Travel between the notes and release; this is not a held stretch.

Practise independently

Compare the blocked and broken versions. Choose the one that stays comfortable and makes the melody clearer. Stop the octave exercise if tension builds.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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5. Bass-to-chord accompaniment

Land quietly after a broad left-hand movement.

Bass-to-chord accompaniment

See the bass and chord as two destinations. After the bass sounds, look at the chord before moving. Practise the chord landing silently, then add the bass. Pedal may connect the sound after the movement is secure, but it must clear with the harmony. The bass should support the phrase without becoming a repeated accent.

Practise · Waltz support

Play bass on beat 1 and light chords on beats 2 and 3.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Support under a tune

Look ahead to the chord while keeping the right-hand phrase moving.

Practise independently

Repeat at a soft dynamic with no pedal. Add shallow pedal offline, clearing after each new bass, and check that adjacent harmonies remain distinct.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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6. Come Thou Fount: travelling accompaniment

Learn the D-major melody first. Keep the flowing eighths below it and let the arm move between the left-hand destinations.

Prepare the score
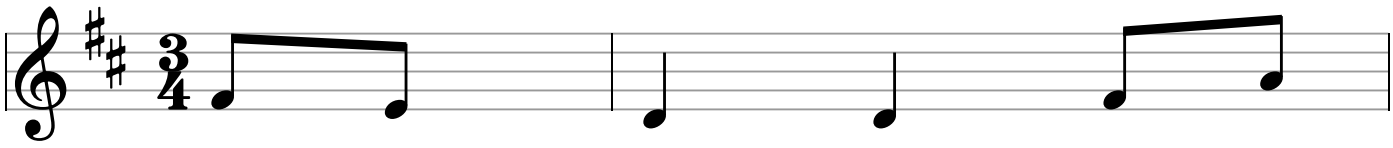
Learn the D-major melody first. Keep the flowing eighths below it and let the arm move between the left-hand destinations.

The left-hand pattern samples the retained source harmonies at each eighth note. It is an original piano accompaniment.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 3/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Learn the D-major melody first. Keep the flowing eighths below it and let the arm move between the left-hand destinations.

Practise · Come Thou Fount: travelling accompaniment

Learn the D-major melody first. Keep the flowing eighths below it and let the arm move between the left-hand destinations.

Make your own musical decision

Loop one crossing at a soft dynamic, then join the approach and following bar.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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7. Crown Him with Many Crowns: octave colour

Use the octave melody only if the span is comfortable. Rehearse it slowly with clear releases. The original source is adapted to half note values and regular 4/4 here.

Prepare the score

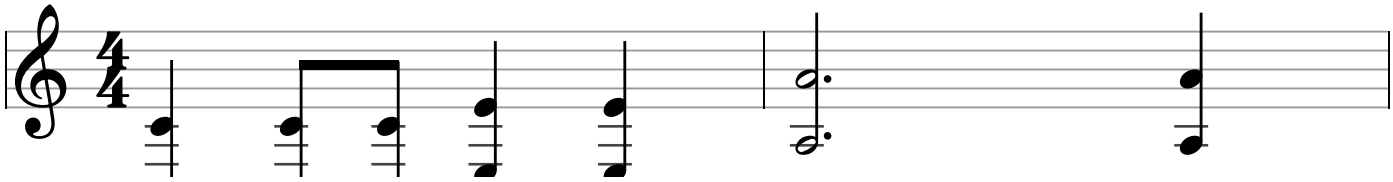
Use the octave melody only if the span is comfortable. Rehearse it slowly with clear releases. The original source is adapted to half note values and regular 4/4 here.

This is a melody-led piano reduction: supporting tones change with the melody. Source inner voices may be moved by octaves or rearticulated; study their original rhythms using the source score.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Use the octave melody only if the span is comfortable. Rehearse it slowly with clear releases. The original source is adapted to half note values and regular 4/4 here.

Practise · Crown Him with Many Crowns: octave colour

Use the octave melody only if the span is comfortable. Rehearse it slowly with clear releases. The original source is adapted to half note values and regular 4/4 here.

Make your own musical decision

Try a single-note melody offline as a lighter alternative. Decide where an octave actually improves the phrase; use the printed octave model for the pitch check.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

8. Eternal Father, Strong to Save: flowing piano

Keep the chromatic melody secure above light moving accompaniment. Move rather than hold a wide left-hand stretch.

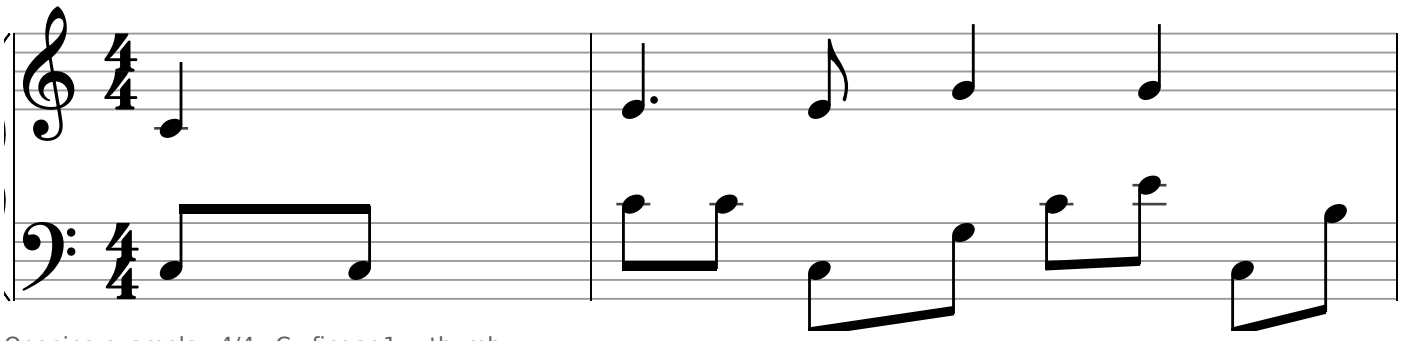
Prepare a complete performance

Keep the chromatic melody secure above light moving accompaniment. Move rather than hold a wide left-hand stretch.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Eternal Father, Strong to Save

Keep the chromatic melody secure above light moving accompaniment. Move rather than hold a wide left-hand stretch.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Keep the chromatic melody secure above light moving accompaniment. Move rather than hold a wide left-hand stretch.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- [ ] Plan black-key fingerings and even crossings in A and E.
- [ ] Choose a minor form by its melodic and harmonic purpose.
- [ ] Coordinate crossings without holding an open stretch.
- [ ] Use release and arm movement instead of gripping.
- [ ] Land quietly after a broad left-hand movement.
- [ ] Keep the chromatic melody secure above light moving accompaniment. Move rather than hold a wide left-hand stretch.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
